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Source: *Journal of Latin American Studies*, Vol. 34, No. 2 (May, 2002), pp. 397-425

Published by: Cambridge University Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3875794>

Accessed: 21-05-2020 23:56 UTC

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COMMENTARY

Blessings of Liberty: The United States and the Promotion of Democracy in Cuba

LARS SCHOULTZ

Only a few visitors to Washington's Arlington National Cemetery wander off the main tourist circuit, attracted by the mast of the battleship *Maine*, to a quiet knoll behind the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier, the resting place for 260 sailors killed when the ship exploded in Havana's harbour in 1898. With the towering monument drawing their eyes upward, these visitors rarely pause to look at the individual tombstones, so virtually no one ever sees the handful of nearby markers identifying the graves of soldiers who participated in something called 'The Cuban Pacification' from 1906 to 1909. And even if an occasional individual should happen to notice these words chiselled into the granite stones, few would be able to explain their meaning – that, at least, has been my experience with a quarter-century of university students, not one of whom has ever heard of The Cuban Pacification.

It was not anything like a war, of course; it was a takeover. Coming only four years after the United States had granted Cuba its independence and two years after Theodore Roosevelt's Republicans had congratulated themselves in their party platform ('We set Cuba free'), the purpose of the 1906 seizure was never clearly explained. The best President Roosevelt could manage came in two sentences before a Harvard audience: 'I am doing my best to persuade the Cubans that if only they will be good they will be happy. I am seeking the very minimum of interference necessary to make them good.' Now, nearly a century later, we need only substitute 'democratic' for 'good' in order to capture post-Cold War US policy toward Cuba – or, as President Clinton explained in his own two sentences about Cuba during the 1999 State of the Union address: 'In this

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hemisphere, every government but one is freely chosen by its people. We are determined that Cuba, too, will know the blessings of liberty.¹

Although future generations of US citizens seem likely to agree with us that democracy is a desirable form of government, our great-grandchildren will probably find today's effort to promote Cuban democracy as baffling as we find the Cuban Pacification. Many of Washington's closest allies already consider it a subterfuge, a convenient excuse for a hostile policy now that its original justification – the Cold War – is over. Most attribute today's unremitting enmity to a peculiar feature of domestic politics: the need to curry favour with Cuban-American voters in Florida. A few observers add that post-Cold War policy also reflects an Executive branch decision not to argue needlessly with Congress over an issue of low salience. Certainly it is true that Congress, urged on by anti-Castro lobbyists, has taken the initiative by writing today's policy of promoting Cuban democracy: the Cuban Democracy Act of 1992 (the Torricelli Act) and the Cuban Liberty and Democratic Solidarity Act of 1996 (the Helms-Burton Act).² The intent of these laws is as transparent as their titles. They expect to help Cubans create a democracy.

The first step is to topple Fidel Castro's government, which is not democratic, if by that term we mean a government operating under the rule of law and held accountable through competitive elections with universal adult suffrage.³ By this definition Cuba has never been a democracy for long, and, as Castro tells anyone willing to listen, it will not become one during his watch.

Who knows how long that might be? Time is catching up with the ageing Cuban leader, although he is poised to outlast his current adversary, North Carolina's Jesse Helms, now serving his final year in the US Senate. But other members of Congress stand ready to take the senator's place and, in any event, he has cemented his view of Cuban democracy into law. Crafted with lapidary attention to detail, the Helms-Burton Act both consolidates and extends the Cuban embargo initiated forty years ago. Then, once the embargo has produced its desired effect, Helms-Burton looks to the future, authorising US assistance to a transitional government

¹ Speech to the Harvard Union, 23 February 1907, *Presidential Addresses and State Papers*, 8 vols. (New York, 1910), vol. 6, pp. 1178–9; *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States: William J. Clinton*, 1999, Book 1, p. 69.

² Torricelli is Public Law 102-484, 23 October 1992, 106 Stat.2575; Helms-Burton is Public Law 104-114, 12 March 1996, 110 Stat.785.

³ By emphasising *procedures* over *outcomes*, this definition will not satisfy the students of contemporary Cuba who prefer to focus on social policy and the democratisation of everyday life – the democratisation of opportunity through universal access to education, for example. On this see Evelyne Huber, Dietrich Rueschemeyer, and John D. Stephens, 'The Paradoxes of Contemporary Democracy: Formal, Participatory, and Social Dimensions,' *Comparative Politics* 29 (April 1997), pp. 323–42.

and, after the transition, continuing aid to a democratic Cuba. The law defines a Cuban transitional government as one that has accomplished eight specific tasks, ranging from abolishing Cuba's equivalent of the FBI to ending interference with the broadcasts of the US government's TV Martí, whose signals come from a blimp tethered to an island near Key West. The central requirement is that this transitional government oversee a free election.⁴

Creating Cuba's democracy

Helms-Burton attempts nothing fundamentally new; the United States has been trying to make Cuba democratic for more than a century. It began with the easy part – seizing Cuba from Spain. On July 1–2 about 15,000 US soldiers, some led by Theodore Roosevelt, defeated about 2,000 Spanish troops at San Juan Hill and the village of El Caney. Then on July 3 the rickety Spanish fleet was overwhelmed as it attempted to escape from Santiago's harbour, and that ended what John Hay called 'a splendid little war'.⁵ US casualties were light, citizens at home were elated, and Theodore Roosevelt was on the fast track to the White House.

The Cuban contribution had been considerable: after three years of warfare the rebels had pinned down nearly all of the 200,000 Spanish troops on the island, and that alone explains why Cubans have always been upset by the term US citizens use for the conflict – the Spanish-American War – which overlooks their role in the proceedings. So, too, did the post-war negotiations. No Cuban helped to negotiate the armistice signed by Spain and the United States in Washington in August; it required the Spanish to relinquish sovereignty over Cuba pending negotiation of a treaty of peace, which was signed in Paris in December, again without Cuban participation. It declared that Cuba 'is, upon evacuation by Spain, to be occupied by the United States'.⁶

Cubans now had a hazy status. The rebels had been widely admired during their struggle against the Spanish, and officials in Washington had argued that Cubans deserved independence, in part because, as Senator Henry Cabot Lodge noted, 'among the principal military officers there are only three of negro blood'; the rest were 'white men, and of good family and position'.⁷ Accordingly, the congressional war resolution had declared that the United States would not annex the island – a declaration known as the Teller Amendment – and in a post-war message President

⁴ Section 205(a)(7) stipulates that neither Fidel Castro nor his younger brother Raúl can be candidates.

⁵ Hay to Roosevelt, 27 July 1898, Roosevelt Papers, Manuscript Division, Library of Congress (hereafter 'LC'). ⁶ 30 Stat. 1754

⁷ Henry Cabot Lodge, 'Our Duty to Cuba,' *Forum* 21 (May 1896), pp. 282, 287.

William McKinley acknowledged this commitment to Cuba's independence, but only after order had been restored and a government created.⁸ That took until mid-1902, and in the intervening years Cuba was ruled by the US Army.

The interregnum would have been briefer had it not been for the Social Darwinists then shouldering their way into power – men such as Senator Lodge, Theodore Roosevelt (elected governor of New York in 1898 and vice-president in 1900), and two of McKinley's principal cabinet members, Secretary of State John Hay and Secretary of War Elihu Root. They wanted to annex Cuba. These jingoists had accepted the Teller Amendment only reluctantly, and now, lacking the votes to rescind it, they tried a different tactic: working through the like-minded Governor-General of Cuba, Leonard Wood, they sought to convince the Cubans to request annexation. As Wood told Roosevelt, 'clean government, quick decisive action and absolute control in the hands of trustworthy men, establishment of needed legal and education reforms and I do not believe you could shake Cuba loose if you wanted to.' Roosevelt assured Lodge that 'in two or three years they will insist on being part of us.'⁹

But Cubans could not be convinced so quickly to become part of the United States, and so Governor-General Wood tried to extend the transition period. 'We are going ahead as fast as we can,' he wrote the president in 1900, 'but we are dealing with a race that has steadily been going down for a hundred years into which we have got to infuse new life, new principles and new methods of doing things. This is not the work of a day or of a year, but of a longer period.'¹⁰ Wood's letter arrived in Washington at a moment when President McKinley's thoughts were turning to his re-election, however, and the rival Democrats were already making political capital out of his administration's rapidly escalating counterinsurgency problem in the Philippines. Seeking to balance that quagmire with progress in Cuba, the president ordered Wood to accelerate the transition.¹¹

The first task was to disenfranchise that part of the Cuban population which had gone furthest downhill. By decree Wood restricted suffrage to Cuban-born males over the age of twenty who could meet one of three

⁸ *A Compilation of the Messages and Papers of the Presidents*, James D. Richardson, ed., 11 vols. (New York, 1907), vol. 10, p. 98.

⁹ Roosevelt to Lodge, 21 July 1899, *Selections from the Correspondence of Theodore Roosevelt* (hereafter *Selections*), Henry Cabot Lodge, ed., 2 vols. (New York, 1925), vol. 1, pp. 413–14; Wood to Roosevelt, 18 August 1899, Roosevelt Papers, LC.

¹⁰ Wood to McKinley, 12 April 1900, Wood Papers, LC.

¹¹ Root to Wood, 14 April 1900, General Classified Files, 1898–1945, Records of the Bureau of Insular Affairs (Record Group [hereafter 'RG'] 350), National Archives (hereafter 'NA').

requirements: the ability to read and write, the possession of property valued at \$250 or more, or military service in the insurgent forces. This eliminated two-thirds of Cuba's males over the age of twenty, and Secretary of War Elihu Root congratulated his general when he learned that 'whites so greatly outnumber the blacks' in the truncated electorate. 'When the history of the new Cuba comes to be written the establishment of popular self-government, based on a limited suffrage, excluding so great a proportion of the elements which have brought ruin to Hayti and San Domingo, will be regarded as an event of first importance.'¹² While Wood therefore had good reason to expect that Cuba's first democratic government would be led by what he generally called 'the decent element,' the governor-general was unwilling to permit much freedom to even this select segment of the Cuban *demos*, as a Yankee owner of one sugar plantation discovered: 'In preparing for the first election, General Wood sent for me and asked me to use my influence in support of a very respectable man whom he wished to elect as *alcalde* of Cienfuegos. I sent for one of the *alcaldes de barrio* and told him my wishes. He told me to have no anxiety; the man I suggested would be elected. I asked him how he proposed to do it. He said it was a simple matter; they would take possession of the ballot boxes and destroy the ballots of the opposition candidates. I told him that was a magnificent idea.'¹³

The wisdom of McKinley's decision to push toward Cuban independence became apparent to Republicans as the situation continued to deteriorate in the Philippines, and especially after the Democratic platform identified imperialism as 'the paramount issue of the campaign.' The Republican platform responded by conceding Cuban independence and arguing that the struggle against Aguinaldo's Philippine rebels was simply an effort 'to confer the blessings of liberty and civilisation upon all the rescued peoples.' Then, in an electoral contest that soon moved away from imperialism to a number of unrelated issues, in 1900 the Democrats lost more heavily than in 1896, and the victorious Republicans, now willing to agree that the election had been a referendum on imperialism, immediately claimed a mandate for the half-century occupation of the Philippines and for the very special type of democracy they were about to impose upon Cuba.

When Governor-General Wood had gavelled Cuba's constituent assembly to order on November 5 1900, not coincidentally one day before the US presidential election, he could see that his effort to

¹² *Ibid.*; Wood to Roosevelt, 8 February 1901, Wood Papers, LC; Root to Wood, 20 June 1900, Root Papers, LC.

¹³ Edwin F. Atkins, *Sixty Years in Cuba* (Cambridge, MA, 1926), p. 322; Wood to McKinley, 12 April 1900, Wood Papers, LC.

manipulate its composition had failed: 'the dominant party in the Convention to-day contains probably the worst political element in the Island.'¹⁴ Since this was the body that would write Cuba's first constitution, and since the US election was over, Wood's first reaction was to press for a delay in the transition process, promising Secretary of War Root 'that at the next municipal elections we shall get hold of a better class of people'.¹⁵ He also re-opened the issue of keeping the island, citing the concerns of leftover Spaniards, whom he was encouraging to forge an alliance with wealthy Cubans – these foreign and creole property owners, he reported, 'are very reluctant to see a change of government, unless it be annexation to the United States'.¹⁶

But the Republicans had made a clear commitment in their platform, and so Wood, Root and like-minded US officials turned to their fallback position: formal independence but continued control over a people considered unprepared for self-government. To this end they fashioned a piece of legislation known as the Platt Amendment, after Connecticut Senator Orville Platt, chair of the Senate Committee on Relations with Cuba. It prohibited the withdrawal of US troops until Cubans had inserted eight novel articles into their new constitution, one of which granted the United States the right to intervene for 'the maintenance of a government adequate for the protection of life, property, and individual liberty'. Cuba was to be a protectorate.

Once McKinley had signed the Platt Amendment into law, Secretary of War Root informed the Cubans that they were obliged to append it to their new constitution. When the constituent assembly refused by a vote of 24 to 2, he instructed Wood to tell the Cubans that the US occupation would continue indefinitely 'if they continue to exhibit ingratitude and entire lack of appreciation of the expenditure of blood and treasure of the United States to secure their freedom from Spain'.¹⁷ With no alternative but capitulation, the constituent assembly grudgingly added the Amendment's eight articles to their constitution; in return, Governor-General Wood presided over Cuba's first transition to democracy, then sailed for home. Shortly before leaving he wrote to assure his new President, Theodore Roosevelt, that 'there is, of course, little or no independence left Cuba under the Platt Amendment'. That had been the plan all along, as Senator Platt noted in his own reassuring letter to a major US investor

¹⁴ Wood to Platt, 6 December 1900, Wood Papers, LC.

¹⁵ Wood to Root, 19 January 1901, Root Papers, LC; Wood to Root, 8 February 1901, Wood Papers, LC.

¹⁶ Wood to Root, 16 June 1901, General Classified Files, 1898–1945, RG 350, NA; Wood to Root, 30 May 1901, Wood Papers, LC.

¹⁷ Root to Wood, 2 March 1901, Root Papers, LC.

on the island: 'The United States will always, under the so-called Platt Amendment, be in a position to straighten out things if they get seriously bad.'¹⁸

Supervising Cuba's democracy

In his 1904 annual message President Roosevelt clearly spoke too soon when he wished that every country washed by Caribbean waters 'would show the progress in stable and just civilisation which with the aid of the Platt amendment Cuba has shown since our troops left the island' – in 1905 Cuba's calm was shattered by the fraudulent re-election of President Tomás Estrada Palma, who was allied with the conservative *moderados*.¹⁹ The electoral abuse had provoked an armed uprising by the opposition *liberales* and, with the rebels poised to seize power, US Consul Frank Steinhart cabled frantically from Havana: '*Absolutely confidential*. Secretary of state, Cuba, has requested me, in name of President Palma, to ask President Roosevelt send immediately two vessels; one to Havana, other to Cienfuegos; they must come at once. Government forces are unable to quell rebellion.'²⁰

'I am so angry with that infernal little Cuban republic that I would like to wipe its people off the face of the earth,' an enraged Roosevelt wrote to a friend. That, however, was not his official response; sensing that the US public had grown weary of his Caribbean adventures (including his recent establishment of a Dominican customs receivership), Roosevelt told Consul Steinhart that 'perhaps you do not yourself appreciate the reluctance with which this country would intervene.'²¹ President Estrada Palma's response was to ask Consul Steinhart to reiterate to Roosevelt that he, the vice-president and the cabinet were determined to resign, 'and therefore the prevailing state of anarchy will continue unless the United States Government will adopt the measures necessary to avoid this danger.'²² Noting that 'disgust with the Cubans is very general', Senator Henry Cabot Lodge told Roosevelt that Congress would not object to a takeover: 'Nobody wants to annex them, but the general feeling is that

¹⁸ Wood to Roosevelt, 28 October 1901, Wood Papers, LC; Platt to Edwin F. Atkins, 11 June 1901, Orville H. Platt Papers, Connecticut State Library, Hartford. For the views of the Constituent Assembly, see Emilio Roig de Leuchsenring, *Historia de la Enmienda Platt*, 2 vols. (Havana, 1935), vol. 1, pp. 125–52.

¹⁹ *Messages and Papers of the Presidents*, vol. 10, pp. 831–2.

²⁰ Steinhart to Secretary of State, 8 September 1906, in 'Appendix E: Cuban Pacification,' *Annual Reports of the War Department for the Fiscal Year Ended June 30, 1906* (hereafter *Annual Reports*) (Washington, DC, 1906), pp. 444–5.

²¹ Roosevelt to Henry L. White, 13 September 1906, Roosevelt Papers, LC; Roosevelt's message was communicated via Acting Secretary Bacon to Steinhart, 10 September 1906, *Annual Reports*, p. 445.

²² Steinhart to Secretary of State, 14 September 1906, *Annual Reports*, pp. 446–7.

they ought to be taken by the neck and shaken until they behave themselves.' With one eye on the upcoming off-year congressional elections, Roosevelt decided instead to send Secretary of War William Howard Taft to negotiate a settlement, warning him to 'remember that we have to do not only what is best for the island but what we can get public sentiment in this country to support.'²³

Within hours of reaching Havana Taft cabled that 'the situation is most serious. The Government controls only coast towns and provincial capitals. Anarchy elsewhere.' Taft had worried from the beginning that something like this would occur – five years earlier, when Cubans had balked at accepting the Platt Amendment, he had written to his brother that 'the trouble in Cuba is just beginning, and the lack of wisdom in the Teller Resolution is beginning to show itself.' The problem was Cuba's political culture – in 1904 Taft had written to a friend that 'the Spanish American, or one educated in the Spanish political school, has no idea of impartiality, and if he is an election officer, regards it as a duty to cheat for his party.'²⁴ This is exactly what he discovered when his ship docked in Havana: the insurrection 'could not have occurred in a country in which the common and ignorant people are not as easily aroused;' in Taft's view, 'the whole thing demonstrates the utter unfitness of these people for self govt.'²⁵ With nine US warships anchored in Havana's harbour, Taft announced that he was establishing a provisional government 'by the authority of the President of the United States', and within days he was writing on letterhead reading 'Office of the Governor, Republic of Cuba, Under the Provisional Administration of the United States'. A disgusted Roosevelt wrote to his son that Taft had struggled to avoid the takeover, but no one could ever 'tell when those ridiculous dagos would flare up over some totally unexpected trouble and start to cutting one another's throats'.²⁶

Thus began the Cuban Pacification. It was intended to be brief – as Roosevelt instructed the War Department, 'our business is to establish peace and order on a satisfactory basis, start the new government, and then leave the island.' These tasks were assigned to a new governor-

²³ Lodge to Roosevelt, 16 September 1906, *Selections*, vol. 2, pp. 232–3; Roosevelt to Taft, 28 September 1906, *Annual Reports*, p. 481.

²⁴ Taft to Roosevelt, 20 September 1906, *Annual Reports*, p. 469; Taft to Charles P. Taft, 17 May 1901 and Taft to Beekman Winthrop, 16 September 1904, both Taft Papers, LC.

²⁵ Taft to Helen Taft, 20 and 22 September 1906; Taft to Charles P. Taft, 4 October 1906, all Taft Papers, LC; US Congress, House, *Annual Reports*, p. 456.

²⁶ *Annual Reports*, pp. 463, 478, 482, 519, 543; Roosevelt to Lodge, 27 September 1906, *Selections*, vol. 2, p. 234; Roosevelt to Taft, 26 September 1906, and Roosevelt to Kermit Roosevelt, 23 October 1906, *Letters of Theodore Roosevelt*, vol. 5, pp. 425, 465.

general, Charles Magoon – an ideal choice, an associate delicately noted, since the Nebraska attorney exhibited ‘the gentle nature which so often accompanies vast bulk’.²⁷ Magoon’s first impression was that the Platt Amendment had contributed to the rebellion by giving ‘the business class’ (a term he used interchangeably with ‘Cubans fully capable of good judgment’) the freedom to ignore politics. But Magoon shared Taft’s view that Cuba’s fiery Hispanic culture was the underlying problem: ‘Like all other people of Spanish origin they are hot blooded, high strung, nervous, excitable and pessimistic.’ Genuine improvement would therefore be slow, for ‘we cannot change these racial characteristics by administering their Government for two years or twenty years.’²⁸

As an alternative to a time-consuming attempt to ‘de-Hispanicise’ Cuban culture, Magoon tried to constrain the excitable Cubans by strengthening their *institutions*, creating an Advisory Law Commission composed of nine carefully chosen Cubans and three US citizens, and chaired by Colonel Enoch Crowder, an Army attorney. It prepared an array of administrative reforms, including a thoroughly revised electoral code that expanded suffrage to nearly all adult males and established proportional representation to encourage the loyal participation of minority parties. Then it turned to the question of whether to create an army. Governor-General Wood had been rebuffed five years earlier when he had requested a permanent US military presence to serve as ‘the moral force to hold these people up to their work until the decent element assumes its normal position in the government of this island.’ But now that Cubans had demonstrated their predisposition to anarchy, Taft hoped that Crowder and Magoon ‘will have sense enough to lay the foundation of an army that will suppress future resorts to violence.’ The Advisory Law Commission accordingly created a new Permanent Army, whose leaders were selected and trained by US officers.²⁹ Then, with his reforms accomplished, Governor-General Magoon called for elections, and in early 1909 he handed Cuba’s presidential sash to José Miguel Gómez, a Liberal, formally ending the Cuban Pacification.

But now the ice had been broken, and Cubans quickly became re-accustomed to seeing US soldiers on their streets. In mid-1912 the Marines briefly returned to quash a complex Afro-Cuban labour and political dispute in Oriente province. That same year President Gómez

²⁷ Roosevelt to Taft, 22 January 1907, *Letters of Theodore Roosevelt*, vol. 5, p. 560; the associate was William Franklin Sands, *Our Jungle Diplomacy* (Chapel Hill, 1944), p. 62.

²⁸ Magoon to Roosevelt, 16 April 1908, Roosevelt Papers, LC.

²⁹ Magoon to Roosevelt, 16 April 1908, Roosevelt Papers, LC; Wood to Root, 8 February 1901, Wood Papers, LC; Taft to Roosevelt, 22 September 1906, Roosevelt Papers, LC; Taft to Charles Taft, 9 October 1906, Taft Papers, LC.

turned the government over to Mario García Menocal, whose fraudulent re-election in 1916 prompted the 1917 'February Revolution' which, from Washington's perspective, could not have occurred at a worse moment – soon after Germany had resumed unrestricted submarine warfare and immediately after Britain had handed Washington an intercepted telegram from German Foreign Minister Arthur Zimmermann. The cable instructed the German ambassador in Mexico City to seek a military alliance with Mexico, offering as an incentive 'the territory lost by her in a prior period in Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona'.³⁰

This heightened concern over the nation's undefended southern flank was compounded by the lobbying of US economic interests. As Cuba's February Revolution began to disrupt the sugar industry, John Foster Dulles, a young attorney with New York's Sullivan and Cromwell, boarded the *Congressional Limited* for Washington. Later that day he wrote to thank his uncle, Secretary of State Robert Lansing, for taking the time to listen to the problems facing his firm's clients – 'companies which own a very large number of sugar estates in the Island of Cuba' – and to repeat the request he had made during his office visit: 'it would be highly desirable to have a United States vessel appear, if only for a short time, in the Manati harbor' on Cuba's northeastern coast.³¹ Two companies of Marines were promptly dispatched to Camagüey and Oriente provinces (including the port of Manatí), ostensibly to protect US sugar interests, but in effect to free up the Cuban troops needed to suppress the February Revolution. One company of 350 US Marines remained in Camagüey for five years.

Logic suggests that these troops should have left once the German threat had been eliminated, once the Liberal revolt had been extinguished, and once US investors had been reassured, but President Woodrow Wilson had one additional goal: to help Cubans become democratic; his general policy, as he told a British envoy, was 'to teach the South American republics to elect good men'.³² Initially preoccupied by the Mexican Revolution and an ambitious domestic policy agenda, Wilson left the details of Cuba's education to Secretary of State William Jennings Bryan, who, as a state department counsellor once observed, seemed

³⁰ Zimmermann to von Eckhardt, 16 January 1917, in *Official German Documents Relating to the World War*, 2 vols. (New York, 1923), vol. 2, p. 1337.

³¹ Dulles to Lansing, 14 February 1917, 337.11/162, General Records of the Department of State (RG59), NA.

³² These words come to us fourth-hand from Burton Hendrick, the biographer of Wilson's ambassador to Britain, Walter Hines Page. Burton J. Hendrick, ed., *The Life and Letters of Walter Hines Page*, 3 vols. (Garden City, NY, 1923–1925), vol. 1, p. 204; for a direct letter expressing the same idea in different words, see Wilson to Tyrrell, 22 November 1913, Wilson Papers, LC.

unable 'to give consecutive thought or really intelligent consideration to anything brought before him'.³³ And since Bryan gathered about him a team of inexperienced Democrats who had learned about foreign policy from Theodore Roosevelt's jingoists, some truly wild ideas were placed upon his desk. Several of the wildest came from Boaz Long, a stockbroker who felt his loyalty to the Democrats merited something more important than the backwater position of US minister to El Salvador. Seeking to attract the attention of Bryan's replacement, Robert Lansing, in 1918 Long proposed a Latin American policy that presaged JFK's Alliance for Progress by four decades: 'Extending our influences over these less favoured people with the idea of educating them and regulating and improving their agricultural and commercial development, and making them good citizens of a democracy.'³⁴

That is exactly what President Wilson and Secretary Lansing were thinking about the obstreperous Cubans, and so Long was promoted to the US legation in Havana. There he was joined by Enoch Crowder, now an army general and back for a second attempt to reform Cuba's tattered democracy. When the two US envoys reported that the Cubans were ignoring their suggestions, in late 1920 the Wilson administration again invoked the Platt Amendment, keeping Boaz Long as minister, but naming Crowder the president's 'Personal Representative on Special Mission' in Cuba and warning the Cuban government that troops would also be sent unless President Menocal 'assumes a receptive attitude in respect to the advice and just recommendations which the President has instructed General Crowder to convey to him'.³⁵

Warren Harding's new Republican administration accepted Boaz Long's resignation in 1921 but continued Woodrow Wilson's policy, promoting Crowder to ambassador and instructing him to force the new government of Alfredo Zayas to launch a crusade for clean government. Crowder's technique was to produce a list of detailed reforms, which he sent to the government as numbered memoranda.³⁶ Implementation was not easy, and backsliding was always a problem, but in time a *modus vivendi* was established: Washington helped the Cuban government obtain loans from New York bankers, and Cubans played along with what came to be known as Crowder's 'Moralization Program'. Many US officials judged the eight-year proconsular mission a success, and some considered it a model for nearby countries – seeking support for a similar

³³ John Bassett Moore, untitled memorandum, 21 October 1913, Moore Papers, LC.

³⁴ Long to Lansing, 15 February 1918, 711.13/55, RG59, NA.

³⁵ The warning to Menocal is Davis to Boaz Long, 4 January 1921, 837.00/1949, RG59, NA.

³⁶ Division of Latin-American Affairs, 'Synopsis of General Crowder's 13 Memoranda,' 14 November 1923, 123 C 8812/51, RG59, NA.

intervention in Nicaragua, in 1928 Senator William Bruce asked his colleagues to 'think of our intervention in Cuba. This is absolutely one of the finest things in human history.'³⁷

Crowder's crowning achievement was the 1924 election of Zayas' replacement, Gerardo Machado, later nicknamed 'the Butcher of Las Villas', in part because that was his profession, and in part because of the method he used to maintain his grip on public office – what one US envoy referred to as Machado's 'pathological obsession that only repressive measures, culminating in acts of hideous cruelty, could stifle the opposition.'³⁸ US officials appreciated the stability he brought to the Island, however, and no one in Washington wanted him to retire when his term expired. Having borne the brunt of his cruelty, Machado's domestic opposition had apparently learned to keep quiet; Ambassador Noble Judah admitted that Machado 'cannot be a candidate in 1928 to succeed himself without violating the Constitution', but concluded that 'if we do not raise these constitutional questions no one else will.'³⁹ After the fraudulent 1928 election Judah reported that 'I have been getting the utmost cooperation from Machado on everything I have asked of him, and it is certainly his policy, not only expressed but acted upon, to play as close to our Government as possible.' That pleased Herbert Hoover's secretary of state, Henry Stimson, who confided to his diary in 1930 that the Machado government 'was not the government that we should care for in America, but that it seemed to be in full control of Cuba; that it was popular with the Army, and that was the main thing in Latin-American countries.'⁴⁰ This was the policy toward Cuban democracy inherited by Good Neighbour Franklin Roosevelt.

However, by early 1933 the Depression had severely weakened President Machado's grip on power, and a member of FDR's transition team warned 'that the Cuban situation is getting worse and that in the near future the Department may be involved'. But at this point any US involvement would have to exclude the Marines because the thinking of the new administration's principal Latin Americanist, Sumner Welles, once an ardent interventionist, had evolved with the times. Helping with a draft of Roosevelt's inaugural address, Welles suggested a flat prohibition on 'the dispatch of the armed forces of the United States to

³⁷ *Congressional Record*, 20 January 1928, p. 1787.

³⁸ Welles to Roosevelt, 18 May 1933, *Franklin D. Roosevelt and Foreign Affairs*, Edgar B. Nixon, ed., 3 vols. (Cambridge, MA, 1969), vol. 1, p. 141.

³⁹ Judah to White, 31 May 1928; White to Judah, 4 and 9 June 1928, Francis White Papers, Herbert Hoover Library, West Branch, Iowa.

⁴⁰ Judah to White, 30 April 1929, Francis White Papers, Herbert Hoover Library, West Branch, Iowa; Stimson Diary, 25 November 1930, Henry Stimson Papers, Yale University.

any foreign soil whatsoever'⁴¹ – a suggestion that became the defining characteristic of the Good Neighbour policy.

Fearing that the severely depressed Cuban economy might provide the tinder for a full-blown political crisis, Roosevelt postponed Welles' appointment as assistant secretary of state and sent him instead to Havana, where the envoy quickly discovered the problem: 'a detestation of the President's person which is unparalleled.' Welles recommended the withdrawal of recognition, and with the envoy's encouragement the Cuban army promptly forced Machado from power, naming a former Cuban ambassador to Washington, Carlos Manuel de Céspedes, as interim chief executive.⁴²

Welles had been promoting the US-born Céspedes for over a decade – in 1921 he had told Enoch Crowder that Céspedes would make an ideal president because of his 'amenability to suggestions or advice which might be made to him by the American Legation.' The problem with this arrangement, as General Crowder had argued, was that the new Cuban president, 'through sheer weakness of character [a reference to Céspedes' rumoured homosexuality], is negligible in any kind of a political crisis'.⁴³ Sensing this weakness, the army's non-commissioned officers, led by Sergeant Fulgencio Batista, escalated a pay dispute into a rebellion and replaced Welles' favourite with a reform-oriented university professor, Ramón Grau San Martín. The indignant Welles asked for 'a temporary landing of possibly a thousand men,' admitting that the literal-minded might consider this a violation of the Good Neighbour policy, but warning Secretary of State Cordell Hull that Batista's rebellious non-commissioned officers 'who are in close touch with Communist leaders in Havana may resort to desperate measures if they become sufficiently drunk'.⁴⁴

As an aide once confided to his diary, Secretary Hull 'is slow in making up his mind, sometimes, it has seemed to me, in situations that call for

⁴¹ Duggan to Wilson, 17 January 1933, 710.11/17761/2, RG59, NA; Welles' undated memo to FDR has a filing date of inauguration day, ('3-4-33') and is in folder: 'Cuba 1933-35, 42-44,' Box 28, President's Secretary's File, FDR Library, Hyde Park, NY.

⁴² For the evaluation of Machado's popularity: Welles to Roosevelt, 18 May 1933, *Franklin D. Roosevelt and Foreign Affairs*, vol. 1, p. 141; for the advice to withdraw recognition: Welles to Hull, 8 August 1933, 837.00/3616, RG59, NA; Welles to Hull, 9 August 1933, *Foreign Relations of the United States* (hereafter FRUS), 1933, vol. 5, p. 344.

⁴³ Sumner Welles, 'Memorandum,' 1 March 1921, 837.00/2216; Crowder, 'Recent Cabinet Crisis,' 21 April 1923, enclosed with Crowder to Hughes, 23 April 1923, 837.00/85, both RG59, NA.

⁴⁴ Memorandum of Telephone Conversation between Hull and Welles, 5 September 1933; Memorandum of Telephone Conversation between Caffery and Welles, 5 September 1933; Welles to Hull, 7 September 1933; Welles to Hull, 8 September 1933, 837.00/3786, all FRUS 1933, vol. 5, pp. 380-404.

rapid action. But his judgment is far better than Sumner's. Sumner, on the other hand, will move like a shot in all situations.' True to this portrayal, Hull put off a decision until he could consult with others; then for reasons related primarily to the principle of non-intervention, the main item on the agenda at the upcoming foreign ministers' conference in Montevideo, he refused Welles's request for troops. Unwilling to concede, Welles waited until Hull had sailed for Uruguay, then plead the case for intervention directly to the president. FDR held firm against an invasion, but he refused to recognise Grau's government, he encircled the island with every available warship – thirty in all – and then he sent Welles back to Havana to plot the government's overthrow, this time by forging an alliance with Fulgencio Batista, the same sergeant who had overthrown Céspedes a few months earlier.

Restoring Cuba's democracy

With Batista now at the helm in Havana, Cuban–US relations were cordial and quiet during the remaining years of the Roosevelt administration. In keeping with the Good Neighbour policy, the Platt Amendment was abrogated in 1934, although Washington insisted that Cuba continue the permanent US lease on its base at Guantánamo. Caribbean stability became a significant concern once war was declared in 1941, and Welles asked FDR to roll out the red carpet for the Cuban chieftain's 1942 state visit, 'since the overthrow of Batista might plunge the Island during this critical period into chaos.' A highlight of the trip was Batista's brief speech to the House of Representatives, where he emphasised the two nations' 'common ideals of democracy.'⁴⁵

This remark was hardly offhand. Almost always in perfect pitch with US policy, Batista would have had to be completely tone-deaf to miss Washington's World War II-era emphasis upon democracy: until they settled on the label of 'the United Nations', the Allies fighting the Axis generally referred to themselves as 'the Democracies' and, at Washington's urging, all four World War II-era inter-American conferences had gone on record not simply as opposing fascism, but as favouring democracy. True, the rhetoric in these conference resolutions lacked any substantive content – they typically declared the Hemisphere's 'adherence to the democratic ideal' – but they coincided with a significant democratisation in Latin American politics, and they probably nudged the process along in Cuba.

Responsibility for this early post-war nudging fell to a group of fairly obscure mid-level officers, since senior policy makers had little time for

⁴⁵ Welles to Roosevelt, 7 December 1942, 837.001/Batista, Fulgencio/80, RG59, NA; *Congressional Record*, 8 December 1942, p. 9229.

the region. Secretary of State James Byrnes, for example, was completely overwhelmed by the problems of post-war recovery, and so his principal act of Latin American policy was to turn responsibility for the region over to a wealthy Democrat, Spruille Braden, who as a young adult had helped administer the Braden Copper Company's mine in Chile. Braden had been hungry for a diplomatic appointment when FDR entered office in 1933, and his designation as a delegate to the 1933 Montevideo conference and as the US representative on the Chaco Peace Commission only whetted this appetite. His first ambassadorship to Colombia came in 1939; then shortly after Pearl Harbor he was named ambassador to Cuba, where he spent nearly all of World War II.

Braden may not have been the best person to nudge Cuba in any direction – Dean Acheson once described him as ‘a bull of a man physically and with the temperament and tactics of one, dealing with the objects of his prejudices by blind charges, preceded by pawing up a good deal of dust.’⁴⁶ In the case of Cuba, Braden's indignation focused not on the absence of democracy – Batista had been fairly elected in 1940 – but on corruption which, Braden reported, ‘has never before been so rampant, so organised, or so profitable for those at the top’.⁴⁷ But in 1944 Batista supervised a fair election (his hand-picked successor lost) and turned the government over to his principal rival, Ramón Grau San Martín, who had moderated his radical views to accommodate US preferences. Braden was pleased, reporting that ‘Grau is fired up with a zeal to improve the lot of the average Cuban and thus far has shown a determination to exercise the powers of the government as a public trust for the good of the Cuban people.’⁴⁸

With Cuba now requiring less attention Braden widened his focus, moving briefly to lead the US embassy in Buenos Aires and then to the position of assistant secretary of state, where he challenged those who continued to believe, as one 1939 State Department memorandum had suggested, that the United States needed to support dictators because ‘in the present stage of cultural and political development of some of the republics this is not only inevitable but perhaps the only way toward stability which can be realistically envisaged.’ Thus, the memo concluded, to promote democracy ‘would only breed political instability and leave the door open for Axis penetration.’⁴⁹ Braden held the opposite opinion:

⁴⁶ Dean Acheson, *Present at the Creation* (NY: Norton, 1963), p. 160.

⁴⁷ Braden to Hull, 29 May 1943, 837.00/9298; Braden to Hull, 22 November 1943, 837.00/9398, both RG59, NA.

⁴⁸ Braden to Stettinius, 19 December 1944, 837.00/12-944; on Grau's moderation, see Braden to Hull, 3 June 1944, 711.37/398, both RG59, NA.

⁴⁹ Notter to Duggan, 12 September 1939, 710.11/24171/2, RG59, NA.

‘What would have occurred had Germans come westward instead of going eastward to Africa? The Latin American dictators and disreputable governments would have sold out to the enemy in a flash.’ And, with the war almost over, ‘to indicate approval of these dictatorships is to go counter to the very principles for which we are fighting the war.’⁵⁰

This effort to promote Latin American democracy was abandoned over Braden’s dead body. With the Cold War heating up, in early 1947 President Truman asked politician James Byrnes to make way for an army general, George Marshall, as secretary of state, and Marshall promptly fired Braden, whose principal failure had been to alienate much of Latin America with his ham-handed effort to oust Argentina’s Perón. Hemispheric solidarity was now more imperative than ever, and Washington was willing to sacrifice the administration’s ‘democracy’ champion as a prelude to befriending Perón, since an accommodating Perón was essential for a successful Rio conference on hemispheric security, scheduled to begin in August. Braden was eased out just before the Rio meeting, and when a new assistant secretary was finally named in mid-1949, he turned out to be a partner in John Foster Dulles’ Wall Street law firm, Edward Miller, Jr., whose interests lay not in promoting democracy but in protecting US investors and fighting communism. Within a year Miller was warning that ‘the basic situation in the hemisphere today is this. The 21 American states together face the challenge of Communist political aggression against the hemisphere.’ Three days later the National Security Council issued a new policy paper that began by warning that ‘Communists in Latin America have the capability of severely weakening any war effort of the United States by interfering with the source and transit of strategic materials, by damaging vital installations, and by fomenting unrest and instability.’ Then came the punch line: ‘In the event of war, the main deterrent to execution of this capability is the ability of the security forces of the Latin American nations.’⁵¹ For the next four decades this rationale – the need for a strong Latin American military to stop communist-induced unrest and instability – became the trump card in any debate over US efforts to promote democracy in Latin America.

With the Truman administration’s foreign policy ducks now rearranged in a quite different order, unfavourable public opinion was the only remaining roadblock to pursuing the containment of communism by

⁵⁰ Braden to Byrnes, 11 July 1945, FRUS 1945, vol. 9, p. 391; Braden, ‘Agenda for Washington,’ 20 January 1945, 837.00/1-2045, RG59, NA.

⁵¹ Department of State *Bulletin* 22 (5 May 1950), p. 770; NSC 56/2, 18 May 1950, FRUS 1950, vol. 1, p. 630.

supporting Latin America's anti-democratic military leaders. The task of explaining this policy shift fell to Louis Halle, a senior official on the State Department's Policy Planning Staff; the site was *Foreign Affairs*. Writing under the pseudonym 'Y' to suggest a comparison with George Kennan's influential 'X' article, Halle told the journal's readers that democracy was simply not on the cards for Latin America, since the region had 'a tradition of political behaviour marked by intemperance, intransigence [sic], flamboyance and the worship of strong men'. Unlike Anglo-Americans, he wrote, Latin Americans admire 'the ruthless hero who tramples down all opposition, makes himself superior to law, and is irresistible to passionate women who serve his pleasure in droves'.⁵²

Post-war Cuban politics seemed to fit this description. Report after report mentioned the 'volatile nature of the people', which was especially evident in the irrational way they turned down the reasonable requests of the US government for favourable treatment of US investors. 'Nothing whatever is obtained from the Cuban Government merely because the request is just and legitimate,' wrote one senior State Department Latin Americanist, who thought it was 'high time that Cuba grows up.'⁵³ Braden's replacement, Ambassador Henry Norweb, saw trouble everywhere he looked – 'chronic administrative inefficiency', 'gangster-student-fanatics' and, in general, 'the conventional Cuban irresponsibility, venality and intermittent violence'. Little improvement would result by removing one or two bad apples from the political barrel, since 'nine out of ten Cuban party leaders, Senators, Representatives, and principal journalists – either Government or Opposition – would fit better into a Rogues' Gallery than a roster of responsible public servants.' True, 'many of them possess the superficial charm of clever children, spoiled by nature and geography – but under the surface they combine the worst characteristics of the unfortunate admixture and interpenetration of Spanish and Negro cultures – laziness, cruelty, inconstancy, irresponsibility and inbred dishonesty.' Fate had dealt the island a poor hand during Europe's colonial expansion, and now 'it is idle but not irrelevant to speculate what might have been the status of this bountiful island community had it been settled by colonists from the British Isles,

⁵² 'Y' [pseud. Louis Halle, Jr.], 'On A Certain Impatience with Latin America,' *Foreign Affairs* 28 (July 1950), pp. 565–79.

⁵³ The 'volatility' comment is Spruille Braden, 'Agenda for Washington,' 20 January 1945, 837.00/1-2045; the senior Latin Americanist is Ellis Briggs, Memorandum of Conversation, 'More from the Cuban ambassador in Denunciation of the 'Good Behavior Clause', 25 June 1947, 837.61351, both RG59, NA. Briggs would later write about being delighted by a transfer to Chile, for 'the few Chileans I had met were excellent people, not gaily irresponsible like the Cubans but sound and hardworking.' *Proud Servant* (Kent, OH, 1998), p. 144.

Scandinavia, French Canada or even China.' Given 'the poisoned roots from which it sprung' (Spain and Africa), Ambassador Norweb saw little hope for Cuban democracy – 'compromise, in the century-old Anglo-Saxon sense, is unfortunately impossible.'⁵⁴

This type of thinking pervaded the US embassy. In 1947, just before the end of a four-year assignment in Havana, Second Secretary H. Bartlett Wells produced a long memorandum, 'A Study in Cuban-American Relations', that emphasised how 'no Cuban is guided by any system of restraints in his political, social, or perhaps even commercial conduct'. Looking over a list of emerging political leaders, Wells commented that 'all these young people got where they did through concerted insubordination. It would be fair to say that organised indiscipline has become, for historical reasons the force of which has not yet passed off, a fetish of Cuban public life.'⁵⁵ This evaluation was reinforced in a more elaborate study by another mid-level career official, James Cortada, who used one unfortunate trait, vanity ('the root of the Cuban spirit of indiscipline'), to explain everything about Cubans, from their absence of ambition to their overindulgence of children. With their 'magnified sense of honour', all Spaniards had more than a desirable amount of vanity, the first of the Seven Deadly Sins, but in Cuba it had become 'excessive and ridiculous'. He warned State Department officials visiting Havana not to be startled by the fireworks that accompany everyday conversations: 'Cubans are prone to be extremely nervous, which, coupled with a tendency to stomach and liver disorders, frequently make them short-tempered and excitable.'⁵⁶

The US embassy was especially critical of the victor in Cuba's 1948 presidential election, Carlos Prío Socorrás – 'clever and astute but lacking in intellectual integrity'. They were equally unimpressed by his cabinet – 'not, by and large, particularly intelligent, well educated or conscientious'. The new prime minister was 'slippery', the treasury minister (the president's brother) was 'known to be venal', and the education minister was 'left of center, unstable'.⁵⁷ Thus it was fortunate that the US–Cuban diplomatic agenda during the Truman–Prío years

⁵⁴ 'Gradual Relapse of Cuban Politics into Conventional Pattern,' 27 March 1946, 837.00/3-2746; Ambassador Norweb to Secretary of State, 14 January 1946, 837.00/1-4446, both RG59, NA.

⁵⁵ H. Bartlett Wells, 'A Study in Cuban-American Relations,' 8 September 1947, 711.37/9-847, RG59, NA.

⁵⁶ James N. Cortada, 'Component Elements of Cuban Temperament,' 4 February 1948, 837.50/2-948 [sic], RG59, NA.

⁵⁷ Walker to Woodson, Daniels and Armor, 'Three Principal Candidates in Cuban Elections,' 1 June 1948, 837.00/6-148; Collins to Secretary of State, 'Political Situation in Cuba,' 21 September 1948, 837.00/9-2148; Embassy to Department of State, 28 September 1948, 837.002/9-2448, all RG59, NA.

consisted primarily of minor commercial disputes, but the State Department found even those difficult to resolve, 'due in no small measure to: (1) a spirit of nationalism fanned by extremists and a vocal communist minority; (2) a psychological feeling of inferiority on the part of a small and comparatively underdeveloped country lying next to a large, powerful and highly developed neighbour; and (3) the low moral and ethical standards of the Cuban governing classes.'⁵⁸

But Washington's primary foreign policy concern was containing communism, and here US-Cuban relations were excellent. 'One thing should always be remembered regarding President Prío,' wrote Ambassador Robert Butler: 'whenever we have asked him anything regarding Cuban foreign policy he has always stated that Cuba will follow United States' leadership which, I feel, is very commendable. We couldn't ask for anything more in this regard.'⁵⁹ Minor foreign policy coordination problems arose from time to time – in early 1951 the State Department noted that Cuba's advocacy of rapid decolonisation had 'caused difficulties for the United States, which is seeking a more enlightened and reasonable attitude' – but the Prío government scored at the top of the chart on the litmus test of anti-communism. A 1951 State Department policy paper noted that 'Cuban relations with the USSR have deteriorated sharply' and that 'Cuba has assumed in the United Nations a position closely aligned with that of the United States on major political problems.' Prío even agreed to reverse Grau's policy of hostility toward anti-communist Latin American dictators in order to accommodate US wishes.⁶⁰

Lurking in the background of the post-war US-Cuban relationship was the shadow of Fulgencio Batista, who had moved to Daytona Beach after handing Grau San Martín the presidency in 1944. With his taste for political power clearly undiminished, in 1948 he had run successfully, in absentia, for the Cuban Senate. Just before returning from his voluntary exile, Batista was asked if he might be interested in running for the Presidency in 1952. 'You never can tell,' he replied. 'Who knows what will happen in the next four years?'⁶¹ Anyone familiar with Batista

⁵⁸ Department of State, 'Policy Statement: Cuba,' 11 January 1951, 611.37/12-2750, RG59, NA.

⁵⁹ Butler to Edward G. Miller, Jr., 27 December 1950, 611.37/12-2750, RG59, NA.

⁶⁰ Department of State, 'Policy Statement: Cuba,' 11 January 1951, 611.37/1-1151; Embassy to Department of State, 'Political Developments in Cuba,' 19 April 1951, 737.00/4-1951, both RG59, NA.

⁶¹ 'Compilation of Election Returns, Cuban General Elections, June 1, 1948,' 28 July 1948, 837.00/7-2848; Butler to Secretary of State, 'Political Situation in Cuba,' 26 August 1948, 837.00/8-2648; V. Lansing Collins, Jr., to Secretary of State, 'Recent Remarks of Batista Appearing in the Habana Press,' 13 September 1948, 837.00/8-1348; Butler to Secretary of State, 22 November 1948, 837.001 Batista, Fulgencio/11-2248, all RG59, NA.

knew – of course he was interested. But as the campaign for the 1952 election got underway, the embassy reported that his chances were not promising, and an opinion poll gave him less than fifteen percent of the vote.⁶² Three months before the election Batista countered by turning to the Cuban army, informing Cubans that something called a ‘Revolutionary Junta’ had ‘decided that I should assume the office of chief of state and that I should take charge of organising and directing the executive and legislative powers, all their powers and functions resting in me.’ He promised to remain in office only ‘for the period required to re-establish order, peace, and public confidence,’ then cede power to the winner of a fair election.⁶³

The US embassy accepted Batista’s coup with a shrug. ‘Until Cubans learn that discipline and sacrifice are a necessary part of democracy, the upsets such as just occurred will be inevitable.’ The Prío administration had been corrupt, and ‘whether the new group under Batista will be any better is a question. Governments in Cuba are made up of Cubans.’⁶⁴

The Truman administration nonetheless delayed recognition for over two weeks while it awaited Batista’s assurances on three issues: an indication that there would be constitutional continuity (i.e., a rescheduled election), a promise of friendly treatment of US investors, and a tougher attitude towards communism.⁶⁵ None of these posed a problem, and on March 24 Secretary Acheson asked President Truman for permission to recognise Batista, citing his agreement to all three preconditions. A much-relieved Batista told the press that ‘no one can ignore the significance of the friendly decision of the American Government in terms of the maintenance of relations of affection and business.’⁶⁶ On the day of recognition Assistant Secretary Edward Miller wrote to a colleague that ‘from the cold-blooded standpoint of US interests, we have nothing to worry about Batista who is a proven friend of ours, and who might possibly be tougher on the commies than Prío was.’⁶⁷ Then Miller paid a goodwill visit to Havana. ‘I deeply appreciate your receiving me,’ wrote the assistant secretary in his thank-you note to Batista. ‘Having followed your illustrious career for 20 years and having known of the friendship

⁶² Embassy to Department of State, 19 December 1951, 737.00/12-1951, RG59, NA, includes the *Bohemia* survey. ⁶³ *Gaceta Oficial*, 10 March 1952, p. 4610.

⁶⁴ Embassy to Department of State, 11 March 1952, 737.00/3-1152, RG59, NA.

⁶⁵ Briefing memo for pending meeting at Department of State between Cuban Chargé and Edward Miller, Jr., 18 March 1952, 737.00/3-1852, RG59, NA.

⁶⁶ Acheson to Truman, ‘Memorandum for the President,’ 24 March 1952, FRUS 1952-54, vol. 4, p. 871; Batista’s 27 March 1952 press statement is enclosed with Beaulac to Secretary of State, 28 March 1952, 737.02/3-2852, RG59, NA.

⁶⁷ Edward G. Miller, Jr., letter to Claude Bowers, 27 March 1952, Assistant Secretary lot files, Box 4, RG 59, NA.

which you have always had for my country and in particular for the members of my family, it was a special pleasure at last to have met you in person.⁶⁸

The US embassy reported that 'Cuba has been set back many years in its development of constitutional processes';⁶⁹ indeed, Cuba was now more firmly established than ever as just another banana republic, with a military dictator who promised to fight communists, to welcome US investors, and, if possible, to cover his naked dictatorship with a modest veil of electoral legitimacy. When an election was finally held in late 1954 no one was surprised that Batista garnered 87 per cent of the popular vote, since his opponents had all withdrawn, charging fraud. The US embassy tried to place the election in the best possible light, labelling the opposition's charges 'unconvincing', 'flimsy', and 'pure obstructionism', but it was difficult to put a positive spin on a one-candidate race and, regardless of the numbers Batista concocted, the State Department's Cuban desk officer had reported all along that 'despite efforts to win popular support, the regime is unpopular'.⁷⁰

By this time Washington's wartime policy of promoting democracy was ancient history, and no one raised an eyebrow when Batista's Cuba, Somoza's Nicaragua, Trujillo's Dominican Republic and Castillo Armas' Guatemala were all included in Vice President Richard Nixon's 1955 goodwill tour of the Caribbean and Central America. 'His continuance in office is probably a good thing from the standpoint of the US,' read the briefing memo on Batista that was handed Nixon on the eve of his departure: 'Is friendly to the US, admires the American Way of Life, and believes in private enterprise.'⁷¹ Although the memo warned that most Cubans opposed Batista, Nixon's toast at a state dinner in Havana cantered on a favourable comparison between the Cuban dictator and the most revered public figure in US history: 'This month we, in the United States, are celebrating the birthday of Abraham Lincoln,' he began. 'As we celebrate his birthday we think of the fact that he is a man who has done much for our country and he is a symbol to every young American that regardless of his background, however humble it may be, he may

⁶⁸ Edward G. Miller, Jr., to Fulgencio Batista, 15 December 1952, 737.11/12-1552, RG59, NA.

⁶⁹ Embassy Weekly Report to the Department of State, 14 March 1952, 737.00(w)/3-145, RG59, NA; Acheson to Truman, 'Memorandum for the President,' 24 March 1952, FRUS 1952-54, vol. 4, p. 871.

⁷⁰ Embassy to Department of State, 'Joint Weekly Report' for 3 and 10 November and 22 December 1954, 737.00(w)/11-354, 11-1054 and 12-2254; Topping to Rubottom, 'Summary Statement of Relations between the United States and Cuba,' 26 September 1952, 611.37/9-2652, all RG59, NA.

⁷¹ Embassy to Department of State, 'Political Aspects - Briefing Book on Cuba,' 1 April 1957, 737.00/4-157, RG 59, NA.

someday be the president of his country. And it seems to me that our President-elect, President Batista in Cuba, is also a symbol of that with the people of Cuba. A man of humble background, but a man who has been a leader of his country in the past and who now comes again to the Presidency to lead his country to even greater things in the future.' The vice president also thanked Batista for 'Cuba's continuing cooperation with my country in the defence of the principles of freedom and democracy.'⁷²

Nixon's lack of interest in promoting democracy was widely shared. A week after the vice president's Havana toast, Treasury Secretary George Humphrey began a discussion about Latin America at a meeting of the National Security Council by asserting that 'wherever a dictator was replaced, Communists gained. In his opinion, the US should back strong men in Latin American governments.' President Eisenhower agreed, noting that 'free government cannot work among Latins'⁷³ – or, as Louis Halle had recently argued in the pages of *Foreign Affairs*, Latin Americans admire 'the ruthless hero who tramples down all opposition, makes himself superior to law, and is irresistible to passionate women who serve his pleasure in droves.'

'Democratising' Cuba's revolution

The *New York Times* began its coverage of Fidel Castro's insurgency exactly two years after Nixon's toast. 'Thousands of men and women are heart and soul with Fidel Castro,' wrote Herbert Matthews, and his strength lay not only in his charisma ('the personality of the man is overpowering') but in his message, his 'strong ideas of liberty, democracy, social justice, the need to restore the Constitution, to hold elections.' Castro's struggle was 'more than an effort by the outs to get in and enjoy the enormous spoils of office'; rather, it was a fundamental shift in political opinion. 'The old, corrupt order in Cuba is being threatened for the first time since the Cuban Republic was proclaimed early in the century.' Then came the policy-relevant punch line: 'It is disturbing to find the opposition, which contains some of the best elements in Cuban life, is today bitterly or sadly anti-United States.' But how could there be anything except animosity, Matthews continued, when the United States was helping a tyrant repress the island's population? 'While I was there, seven tanks were delivered in a ceremony headed by Ambassador

⁷² 'Toast by the Vice President to the President of Cuba, Havana (National Palace),' undated [but 8 February 1955], Richard M. Nixon Pre-Presidential Papers, Series 361, Box 2, NARA, Laguna Niguel.

⁷³ 'Memorandum of Discussion at the 237th Meeting of the National Security Council, Washington, February 17, 1955,' FRUS 1955-1957, vol. 6, pp. 4-5.

Gardner. Every Cuban I spoke with saw the delivery as arms furnished to General Batista for use in bolstering his regime and for use “against the Cuban people”.⁷⁴

Two years later Fidel Castro sat atop one of Fulgencio Batista’s US-supplied tanks in his Havana victory march. At first no one in Washington knew what to make of the revolution, but one of Washington’s immediate reactions was to develop a strong desire to promote democracy in Cuba. Thus while Vice President Nixon had said nothing about Batista’s fraudulent election during his 1955 visit to Havana, democracy appeared at the very top of his agenda when he met with Castro during the Cuban leader’s visit to the United States in April 1959. During their hour-long discussion Nixon repeatedly encouraged Castro to hold elections promptly and to respect the building blocks of democracy, especially freedom of the press. He found Castro unresponsive: ‘in every instance he justified his departure from democratic principles on the ground that he was following the will of the people’ and that ‘the people did not want elections because the elections in the past had produced bad government’.⁷⁵ A State Department analysis of the visit echoed this theme, warning that Castro ‘does not have the same idea of law and legality as we have in the United States. He appears to confuse the roar of mass audiences with the rule of the majority in his concept of democracy’.⁷⁶

Fidel Castro is not a democrat, but it was his threat to US security and economic interests that led to the 1961 proxy invasion at the Bay of Pigs and the equally unproductive efforts to murder the Cuban leader. But after ‘at least eight plots involving the CIA to assassinate Fidel Castro from 1960 to 1965’, all but the most incurable optimists concluded that Castro would probably never smoke one of the cigars the CIA had saturated with poison (‘a botulinum toxin so potent that a person would die after putting one in his mouth’), nor would a CIA agent ever get close enough to inject Castro with insecticide using a ballpoint pen rigged with a hypodermic needle ‘so fine that the victim would not notice its insertion’⁷⁷ – and so the United States dropped its vendetta against Cuba’s leader in order to concentrate upon the approach utilised today to promote Cuban democracy – strangling the nation’s economy. With Congressional approval (an election-year House vote of 396 to 0), in mid-1960 President Eisenhower closed the door to Cuban sugar; then he placed an embargo

⁷⁴ *New York Times*, 24 February 1957, pp. 1, 34; 25 February 1957, pp. 1, 11; 26 February 1957, p. 13.

⁷⁵ Nixon’s memorandum is reprinted in *Diplomatic History* 4 (Fall 1980), pp. 426–431.

⁷⁶ ‘Memorandum Prepared in the Department of State,’ 23 April 1959, FRUS, 1958–60, vol. 6, p. 482.

⁷⁷ US Congress, Senate, *Alleged Assassination Plots Involving Foreign Leaders*, 94th Cong., 1st Sess., 1975, pp. 71, 73, 89.

on all US exports to Cuba except food and medicine, and in early 1962 the Kennedy administration expanded the ban on sugar to include all other imports from the Island, and that was that – since February 7 1962, any US national who has sold anything to Cuba or purchased anything made in Cuba without first obtaining permission from the US government has violated at least one law, typically the Trading with the Enemy Act.⁷⁸

Before he left office President Eisenhower also introduced what has slowly emerged as today's thorniest economic issue – an attempt to halt third-country trade with Cuba. This began three days after the export embargo, when he asked Canada to prevent its ports from being used to circumvent the US action; in early 1962 the Kennedy administration converted this request to a demand by announcing an unenforceable ban on the re-export to Cuba of US-made goods, and in 1963 it prohibited any foreign merchant ship which docked in Cuba from subsequently transporting goods financed by the US government. Then in the 1990s Cuban-Americans and non-Cuban conservatives such as Senator Helms updated this strategy. Indeed, the most controversial feature of both the 1992 Cuban Democracy Act and the 1996 Cuban Liberty and Democratic Solidarity Act is their attempt to drag others into the US quarrel with Cuba. Helms-Burton in particular permits the owners of property confiscated by the Castro government to use US courts to sue any foreigner who subsequently purchases or otherwise 'traffics' in that property.⁷⁹

This is not a complex issue. Every government on earth recognises the right of a sovereign state to nationalise private property for public purposes – the right of eminent domain – but this right entails the obligation to provide compensation, and US nationals have never received a dime for their nationalised Cuban property, all of which remained in the Castro government's hands until the early 1990s, when the end of Soviet subsidies forced a dramatic shift in Cuba's economic policy, and the Castro government began signing management contracts and selling part-ownership of this nationalised property to investors from Europe, Canada and elsewhere. The issue raised by Title III of Helms-Burton is whether these new investors are liable to the previous US

⁷⁸ The original Trading with the Enemy Act (PL65–71, 6 October 1917, 65 Stat.411) was recodified in 1977 (91 Stat.1625, 28 December 1977). The prohibition on travel (but not trade) was lifted briefly during the Carter administration.

⁷⁹ Section 302(a)(6) prohibits US courts from invoking the Act of State doctrine to refuse to adjudicate a case involving the Cuban government's confiscation and subsequent sale of property previously owned by US citizens. Although exceptions have occurred, this doctrine (that the courts of one state will not sit in judgment of the acts of another) has traditionally been accepted by the US judiciary – the classic statement is *Underhill v. Hernández* (168 US 250).

owners. Today's Pizza Hut executives would say no, arguing that their Moscow property was legitimately acquired from the Soviet-Russian state, even if the state had acquired ownership in 1917 through uncompensated confiscation; so, too, would today's heirs of nineteenth-century US homesteaders, who would presumably argue that the land they have inherited was legitimately acquired by their forebears from the US government, even if that government had acquired ownership from Native Americans without compensation. And so do today's foreign investors in Cuba, who argue that questions of compensation for acts committed by the Cuban state a generation ago are no concern of theirs. They suggest that the aggrieved former owners seek compensation from the Cuban government, either through diplomatic channels or the Cuban courts.

Senator Helms responds that the Cubans have no intention of paying. He may be correct, but neither he nor anyone else knows for sure, because the United States has refused to discuss compensation since September 27 1960, when the State Department, wagering that Castro would soon be gone, instructed the embassy in Havana to break off negotiations – 'our best bet is to wait for a successor regime'.⁸⁰ Over the years the Castro government has settled comparatively small claims with citizens of seven other countries, and it has never rejected the principle that nationalisation must be accompanied by compensation, but Cubans have always tied the compensation of US nationals to an end of the embargo, arguing that only export earnings can generate the money needed for payment. They have also sought to trump US claims by indicating their intention to pursue a much larger counter-claim for damages caused by the embargo – the *bloqueo* that they consider illegal under international law.⁸¹

But all this is beside the point. Every Cuban official knows that the United States is never going to discuss such counter-claims, and every US official knows that Helms-Burton is not aimed at securing compensation;⁸²

⁸⁰ Mann to Bonsal, 27 September 1960, FRUS 1958–1960, vol. 6, pp. 1073–4.

⁸¹ The original 8,816 claims were valued at \$1.8 billion and with interest now exceed \$6 billion. There are an additional 75,000 to 200,000 claims by Cuban-Americans who were not US nationals at the time of the Cuban Claims Program, but are now entitled to the help of the US government in recovering their property. The Foreign Claims Settlement Commission estimates that these claims 'could run easily into the tens of billions of dollars.' 'Settlement of Outstanding United States Claims to Confiscated Property in Cuba,' Report to Congress Under Section 207 of the Cuban Liberty and Democratic Solidarity Act of 1996, undated report accompanying Barbara Larkin, Assistant Secretary of State for Legislative Affairs, to Senator Jesse Helms, 27 September 1996. The current Cuban claim for economic damages caused by the embargo is \$121 billion. See 'Report to the Secretary General of the United Nations Organization on Resolution 55/20,' March (?) 2001, available at www.cubaminrex.cu.

⁸² Section 206(6) of Helms-Burton requires a democratically elected Cuban government to be making 'demonstrable progress in returning to United States citizens ... property

its purpose, clearly stated in the title, is to overthrow a government believed to be stifling Cuban democracy, and it aims to do so primarily by weakening the Cuban economy. That, however, is no longer easily accomplished. Having broken economic ties with the island long ago, there is no mechanism left with which Washington can exert additional economic pressure – except one: the United States can threaten third countries with reprisals if they refuse to cooperate with the US effort.

Underlying this threat is the belief that a connection exists between a weak Cuban economy and a democratic transition. US officials have been confident of such a connection since 1960, when Representative Harris McDowell told his House colleagues that ‘if Cuba’s splendid people understand they must sell their sugar or their economy will be destroyed they will themselves find a way to deal with the present misleaders and fomenters of hatred.’⁸³ Elegant in its simplicity, McDowell’s logic was that Cubans would overthrow the Castro government when pushed to the edge of economic disaster. But McDowell did not live to see his logic confirmed, for the Cubans found another country to purchase their sugar. Now the Soviet Union is gone, however, and Senator Helms is determined to force a test of Representative McDowell’s hypothesis; the core of Helms-Burton is an effort to ensure that Cubans have no third-country option. This time Cubans will behave the way the United States wants them to behave – democratically – or they will face economic calamity.

In practical terms, today this requires that private capital not replace Soviet subsidies. Four decades ago Washington handled this requirement by telling the investors under its jurisdiction that any dealings with Cuba would lead to prosecution under the Trading with the Enemy Act and, with some very modest exceptions, the United States did not need to convince third-country investors because the Cuban government had little interest in their money. But for the past decade Cuba has been vigorously courting entrepreneurs from other countries, many of whom have demonstrated their willingness to fill some of the gaps left by the end of Soviet subsidies. Washington cannot prevent these foreign capitalists from investing in Cuba, but it can threaten to tie them up in US courts, where the legal costs of a prolonged dispute can easily exceed any profits to be made in Cuba.

The governments of Canada and the entire European Union believe that this threat undermines a central principle of the post-war international

taken by the Cuban Government ... or providing full compensation,’ but there is no definition of ‘demonstrable progress.’

⁸³ *Congressional Record*, 30 June 1960, pp. 15229.

economic regime: Helms-Burton, they say, is an attempt to exercise extraterritorial jurisdiction by enforcing a secondary boycott, and secondary boycotts are prohibited by GATT/WTO rules. A direct confrontation – adjudication by the World Trade Organisation, where the United States would almost certainly lose – has only been avoided by a provision allowing the US president to suspend this part of the Act indefinitely, six months at a time. But as this threat has continued to hang over their heads, Washington's closest allies have become increasingly vocal critics of US policy, particularly in the United Nations. In 1992, the year Congress passed the Cuban Democracy Act, the General Assembly first voted on a resolution urging the United States to end its embargo, and while the measure passed by a vote of fifty-nine to three, most US allies (seventy-one in all) abstained. In the ninth vote in November 2001 the United States found only Israel and the Marshall Islands at its side – three against one hundred and sixty-seven.

General Assembly votes have rarely changed US policy, however, and even a no-confidence vote of this magnitude will probably not encourage fresh thinking in Washington unless it is accompanied by a threat to the integrity of the World Trade Organisation, upon which the United States depends to enforce fair trade practices. Until that threat arises or some other dramatic event occurs, officials in Washington will probably continue to pursue a policy created in the early 1960s: first destroy an unfriendly undemocratic government by strangling its economy, then help create a friendly democratic government.

If one had only past experience as a guide to predict the future, then the best wager would be that the United States will eventually make the Cubans yield – it always has. But as Theodore Roosevelt discovered a century ago, it is one thing to make a people yield and another to make them good. That seems particularly true about today's Cuba policy, which equates 'good' with 'democratic', for it is based upon the unfounded belief, common among absolutists, that democracy is about ousting tyrants and installing democrats – or, as Woodrow Wilson phrased it, about teaching Latin Americans to elect good men. The problem, and the inescapable conclusion to be drawn from the 100-year history of US-Cuban relations, is that there are no 'good men' waiting on the Cuban sidelines for an opportunity to govern as democrats once the United States has forced the island's current undemocratic leaders to yield. Ignoring this history, each new Washington generation vows to help improve Cuba, generally with the understanding that there are limits to what can be achieved given the Island's Hispanic population. Today's generation led by Senators Helms and Torricelli appears determined to improve Cuba even if it means destroying the country's economy – or, as

Senator Lodge phrased it in 1906, even if US officials have to shake the Cubans by their necks until they behave themselves.

But democracy – the type of democracy promoted in US policy – is not about replacing bad leaders with good leaders; rather it is a *method of governance*, simply one way (but, most of us would argue, the best way) that people have developed to get along *without* shaking one another by the neck. Democracy is therefore best conceived as a never-ending process of non-violent contestation and accommodation, a process that requires the slow, often-painful and never-ending perfection of rules and procedures in a crowded environment where everyone has a right to help determine public policy. That is why successful democracies are invariably characterised by leaders who have honed their abilities to negotiate and compromise – to accept less than an entire loaf today and then come back for more tomorrow. Democracies thrive where people know how to bargain, to dicker, to haggle.

To observe small children playing in a sandbox is to understand that these are acquired skills. Nobody is born a democrat. People become democrats by sharpening their negotiating skills slowly, through debates with others who disagree, often in fundamental ways, and often over truly important issues. Cubans were clearly not successful in developing these political skills during their first century of independence, even though the United States was helping almost continuously, but only one US official has appeared to recognise that this assistance might have been a major part of the problem. This epiphany came during The Cuban Pacification, when Governor-General Charles Magoon noticed that the Platt Amendment had encouraged Cubans to opt out of politics; it had created the belief that, whatever the problem, ‘the United States should and will attend to the matter.’⁸⁴

Here, then, is the fatal flaw undermining the century-long US effort to promote democracy in Cuba, seen most recently in the 1996 Helms-Burton Act and the 1999 State-of-the-Union announcement that the United States is determined that Cubans enjoy the blessings of liberty: both retard any effort by twenty-first-century Cubans to begin negotiating among themselves the thousands of issues, large and small, that continuously arise out of human interaction. Both encourage the Cuban exile community to continue doing what most of it has done since 1959 – stand on the sidelines in Miami, wearing its intransigence as a badge of honour while pushing the United States to attend to the matter. And, logic suggests, both encourage an equal intransigence among the Cubans led by Fidel Castro. No rational Cuban on either side of the Straits of Florida

⁸⁴ Magoon to Roosevelt, 16 April 1908, Roosevelt Papers, LC.

would go through the arduous process of negotiation and compromise if, in the end, the United States will decide who gets everything.⁸⁵

Of course, it may be that Cubans do not want to create a democracy, with or without US assistance. They may prefer one of the three principal alternatives, although it is doubtful that they would choose either anarchy (from the Greek *anarchos*, rulerless) or monarchy (from the Greek *monos*, alone). But like the United States for much of its history, they might prefer some form of oligarchy (from the Greek *oligos*, 'few'). Or they may prefer a type of democracy that would seem strange to US citizens – perhaps one where the popular vote determines who becomes the president, or one where the playing field is levelled by public campaign funding, or one where voting machines actually work. All that is not for the United States to determine for Cubans, as investment banker Dwight Morrow tried to tell Ambassador Enoch Crowder during a 1922 business trip to Havana. 'Of course, the Government in Cuba has been and is very bad. It is possible, yes, it is probable, that the United States might run Cuba much better. As I get older, however, I think I become more and more convinced that good government is not a substitute for self-government. The kind of mistakes that America would make in running Cuba would be different from those that the Cubans themselves make, but they would probably cause a new kind of trouble and a new kind of suffering.'⁸⁶

Both a committed democrat and an exceptionally accomplished negotiator, Morrow would no doubt be disappointed by the continued absence of liberal democracy in Cuba, but he would probably write much the same letter today. And since what he wrote in 1922 had no impact whatever on US policy, today he might bolster his argument by including a copy of Thomas Jefferson's enduring contribution to democratic practice, which the Virginia oligarch and his co-revolutionaries tacked up on walls throughout the thirteen British colonies in 1776: it is that all people, including presumably the Cubans, have the right to institute their own government, laying its foundation on such principles, and organising its powers in such forms, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their safety and happiness.

⁸⁵ As Whitehead notes, 'a democratic regime may originate from an act of external imposition', but 'intimidation risks destroying the social prerequisites for democratic compromise and accommodation'. Laurence Whitehead, 'The Imposition of Democracy,' in Lowenthal (ed.), *Exporting Democracy*, pp. 216–17, 234.

⁸⁶ Morrow to Crowder, 26 May 1922, Dwight Morrow Papers, Amherst College, Amherst, Massachusetts.